CSS Flexbox Cheat Sheet

Beginning HTML & CSS · Activity 3 Reference · 11 Tasks: display, flex-direction, justify-content, align-items, flex-wrap, gap, flex-grow, align-self

PARENT — Applied to flex container

CHILD — Applied to item

main

PARENT display: flex

Activates flexbox. Turns any element into a flex container. Direct children become flex items and arrange in a row by default.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
display: flex;
```

Tip: Nothing happens until you add this! Start every flexbox layout here.

PARENT flex-direction

Sets the main axis direction. Row (default) arranges items left-to-right. Column stacks them top-to-bottom.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
row  (default)
row-reverse
column
column-reverse
```

Tip: Use column for mobile layouts or vertical nav menus.

PARENT justify-content

Distributes items along the MAIN axis. Controls horizontal spacing when flex-direction is row.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
flex-start  (default)
flex-end
center
space-between
space-around
space-evenly
```

Tip: space-between = logo LEFT, links RIGHT in a navbar!

PARENT align-items

Aligns items along the CROSS axis. Controls vertical alignment when flex-direction is row.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
stretch  (default)
flex-start
flex-end
center
baseline
```

Tip: align-items: center is the easiest way to vertically center anything!

PARENT flex-wrap

By default, items shrink to fit one line. wrap lets them spill onto new lines when space runs out.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
nowrap  (default)
wrap
wrap-reverse
```

Tip: Essential for responsive layouts — prevents overflow on small screens.

PARENT gap

Adds consistent space BETWEEN items. Cleaner than adding margin to each child individually.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
gap: 1rem;
gap: 10px 20px;  (row col)
row-gap / column-gap
```

Tip: Use gap instead of margins on children — simpler and more predictable.

CHILD flex-grow

How much an item grows to fill available space. 0 = don't grow. 1 = take equal share. 2 = take double share vs. siblings with 1.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
flex-grow: 0;  (default)
flex-grow: 1;
flex-grow: 2;
```

Tip: Give all cards flex-grow: 1 for equal widths. Featured card? Use flex-grow: 2.

CHILD flex-shrink

How much an item shrinks when space is tight. Default is 1 (will shrink). Set to 0 to prevent shrinking.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
flex-shrink: 1;  (default)
flex-shrink: 0;
```

Tip: flex-shrink: 0 on logos/icons keeps them from squishing.

CHILD align-self

Overrides the parent's align-items for ONE item only. Lets a single child break ranks on the cross axis.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
auto  (default)
flex-start
flex-end
center
stretch
```

Tip: Great for nudging one item without changing the whole row.

CHILD flex (shorthand)

Combines flex-grow, flex-shrink, and flex-basis in one line. The most used shorthand in real-world CSS.

VALUES / SYNTAX

```
flex: 1;
flex: none;  (0 0 auto)
flex: 0 0 200px;
flex: auto;
```

Tip: flex: 1 on all cards = equal width. The most common flexbox pattern!